in 2019 to just nine in 2024. Combined with the drop in tally in the other key state, Uttar Pradesh, the saffron party's overall seat share dropped to 240, 32 short of a majority. It came as a major setback for Prime Minster Narendra Modi, who had hoped to command a majority in this third term as he had done in his first two. The recent results in Haryana came as a crucial salve, the surprise victory restoring confidence within the party. But Maharashtra is the big prize. A win for the BJP alliance will help Modi consolidate his hold at the Centre, but a defeat could throw his third term into uncertainty.

THE NATIONAL STAKES ARE AS HIGH. A WIN FOR THE BJP-LED MAHAYUTI WILL HELP MODI FIRM HIS GRIP AT THE CENTRE; A DEFEAT COULD THROW HIS THIRD TERM INTO UNCERTAINTY AND BOLSTER I.N.D.I.A



The stakes are high not just for the BJP but also for the other parties in the two alliances. A win for either of the two factions will determine who is the real Shiv Sena. Likewise for the NCP, where Pawar Sr and his nephew Ajit are locked in a bitter fight to gain control over their flock. For the Congress, after its shock loss in Haryana, if it can help the MVA oust the BJP-led Mahayuti, it will strengthen Rahul Gandhi's campaign to erode the BJP's political capital and be in a stronger position for the next big confrontation—the Bihar assembly polls. The 15 Lok Sabha seats that the Janata Dal (United), or JD(U), won in Bihar make the BJP dependent on it for survival at the Centre. The domino effect of a loss for the BJP in Maharashtra and then in Bihar could hobble the Modi government and dent its ability to push its agenda for governance.

In Maharashtra, the MVA goes into the election with a psychological advantage. On October 23, they also sealed a seat-sharing pact with all three parties fighting 85 seats each (the remaining seats may be left for the smaller allies). The opposition alliance swept 31 out of the state's 48 Lok Sabha seats, leaving the Mahayuti licking its wounds with just 17. The Congress put up a surprisingly good show with 13 seats, while the SS(UBT) and the NCP(SC) won nine and eight seats, respectively. The devil, though, lies in the details. Despite the high number of seats the MVA won, the difference in votes polled by the two fronts was just over 200,000. And even though the MVA had a lead in 158 of the 288 assembly segments and the Mahayuti only in 125, the gap between the votes polled by the two sides would be less than 5,000 in 31 seats. Given that the issues in assembly elections are different from those in a general election, the votes in November could go either way, making it a truly tough fight.

SENA VS SENA

Which faction of the Sena emerges victorious will most likely drive the outcome of this election. In 2019, the combine of the BJP and the undivided Shiv Sena won 161 of the state's 288 seats, with the BJP winning 105 and the Sena 56. But Uddhav Thackeray broke away soon after, miffed at the Sena not getting the CM's post. He joined hands with the undivided NCP and the Congress to form the MVA and became chief minister. That dream lasted only for two and a half years, as Uddhav was forced to resign in June 2022 when Eknath Shinde, his deputy, revolted and took 39 Sena MLAs with him to become chief minister with the BJP's help. Not just that, the Election